

Blackcat Blues

I talk to cats. I can tell what they are thinking, by a **twitch** of the ear, a **flick** of the tail, half shut eyes. I do it back and they get dead worried. Cats like their secrets. Some secrets are big ones.

I had read **stuff** about black panthers in the wild. I didn't think much of it.

So when I crossed a field on Dad's farm and saw a big black cat, I **reckoned** it was a moggie, fifty metres away. Then I realized it was two hundred metres away and it wasn't a moggie. Cool, we had a leopard in the **neighbourhood**. I nearly ran home to tell everybody when I had a thought. Dad keeps sheep and goats. Bad news.



Next day I went to the field for another look, nothing there. I **trudged** along the **hedge**. Nothing. Then I saw something dirty white in a bush. A **heap** of wool. The rest of the sheep was lying **underneath**. I looked around.

"Come on, I said quietly "I know you're there. It's all right." Suddenly he was in front of me. Black and shiny with **fierce** yellow eyes.

"Hi puss," I said, lowering my head and half closing my eyes. He made a **rumbling** noise.

"Look," I said, "I guess you've got to eat, but this is real bad." He **sniffed** the dead sheep. I heard the sound of Dad's Land Rover bumping across the field. He jumped out

"You'd better be careful with the cat," he said. "Don't know how safe he is I couldn't believe it.

"You knew?"

"Yeah, I don't miss much on this farm. We've got a deal, him and me. If a sheep dies, I **chuck** it under the hedge and he eats it. Otherwise he eats rabbits or he's in trouble

I was **stunned**. "You didn't say

"Nobody must know or he'll get shot. He's scared already, **frightened** of being hurt, **miserable** because he's alone. You keep quiet and keep away from the field. Now get in and let's leave him alone."

"But how would you know all this?"

Dad **flicked** a lever into the four wheel drive and we **slithered** through the mud.

"You're not the only one who can talk to cats," he said.

I kept away a week then went for another look. Dad had put a dead lamb under the hedge and I **leant** against a tree watching. I saw the cat coming this time, low in an overgrown ditch. It stopped, ears back, snarling and showing its teeth.

"Easy boy" I said. "You know me. I did the head down **submission** bit. The cat started **inching** towards me, swinging its tail, the pupils of its eyes large back legs shuffling for grip. A voice in my head told me to run; another voice kept saying don't move.



"It's all right, you know me," **whispered**. Then I realized. This one was small, a different leopard. That was my only thought as it charged. I just **sort of** stood and watched. It was so quick. But not as quick as the other cat which hit it in mid-air as it **leapt**. The force rolled them away into the bushes, crashing down, spitting, **snarling, growling**. Then it all went quiet. The big one got up and stood over the little one which was calming down. Then very gently he began to lick its face. He looked up at me and half closed his eyes. I did the same.

"Thanks" I said. "That was brilliant. You'll tell her about the deal with Dad, won't you?."

Vocabulary

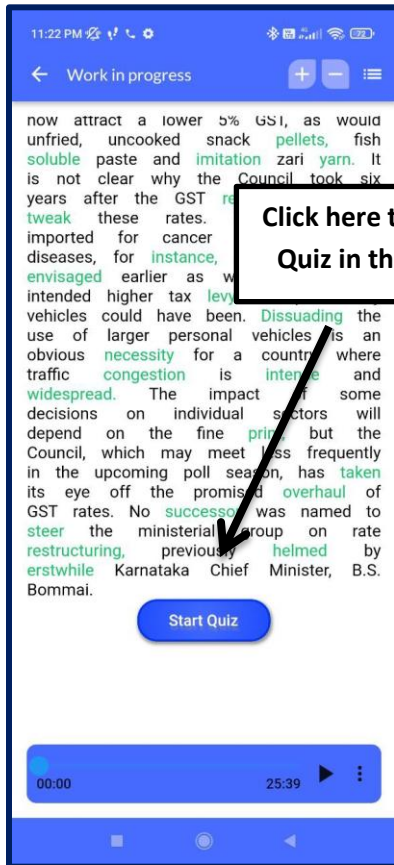
1. **Twitch** (noun) – jerk, spasm, tremor, quiver, flick झटका / फड़कन
2. **Flick** (noun) – snap, swish, tap, stroke, flip झपक / चटाक
3. **Stuff** (noun) – things, items, belongings, materials, objects चीजें / सामान
4. **Reckon** (verb) – think, believe, assume, guess, consider मानना / समझना
5. **Neighbourhood** (noun) – locality, area, community, vicinity, region पड़ोस / इलाका
6. **Trudge** (verb) – plod, slog, stumble, hike, trek थककर चलना
7. **Hedge** (noun) – fence, boundary, enclosure, barrier, shrubbery झाड़ी / बाड़
8. **Heap** (noun) – pile, mound, stack, cluster, accumulation ढेर
9. **Underneath** (preposition) – below, beneath, under, at the bottom of, lower than के नीचे
10. **Fierce** (adjective) – ferocious, intense, wild, aggressive, violent उग्र / क्रोधित
11. **Rumbling** (adjective) – growling, grumbling, echoing, thundering, resonant गर्जन करता हुआ
12. **Sniff** (verb) – inhale, smell, scent, whiff, breathe in सूँघना
13. **Chuck** (verb) – throw, toss, fling, hurl, pitch फेंकना
14. **Stun** (verb) – shock, daze, astonish, dumbfound, bewilder चौंका देना
15. **Frightened** (adjective) – scared, afraid, terrified, alarmed, panicked डरा हुआ
16. **Miserable** (adjective) – unhappy, wretched, sorrowful, dejected, gloomy दुखी / परेशान
17. **Flick** (verb) – flip, snap, swat, strike, switch छड़ी या उंगली से मारना
18. **Slither** (verb) – slide, glide, slip, skid, crawl फिसलना / सरकना
19. **Lean** (verb) – rest, recline, tilt, bend, incline टिकना / झुकना
20. **Submission** (noun) – surrender, yielding, obedience, compliance, deference समर्पण
21. **Inch** (verb) – creep, crawl, move slowly, edge, progress धीरे-धीरे आगे बढ़ना
22. **Whisper** (verb) – murmur, mutter, breathe, hiss, say softly फुसफुसाना
23. **Sort of** (phrase) – kind of, somewhat, rather, a bit, to some extent कुछ हद तक / जैसा कुछ
24. **Leap** (verb) – jump, spring, bound, vault, hop छलांग लगाना

25. **Snarling** (noun) – growl, roar, bark, snap,
grumble गुस्से से दांत दिखाना / गुर्राहट

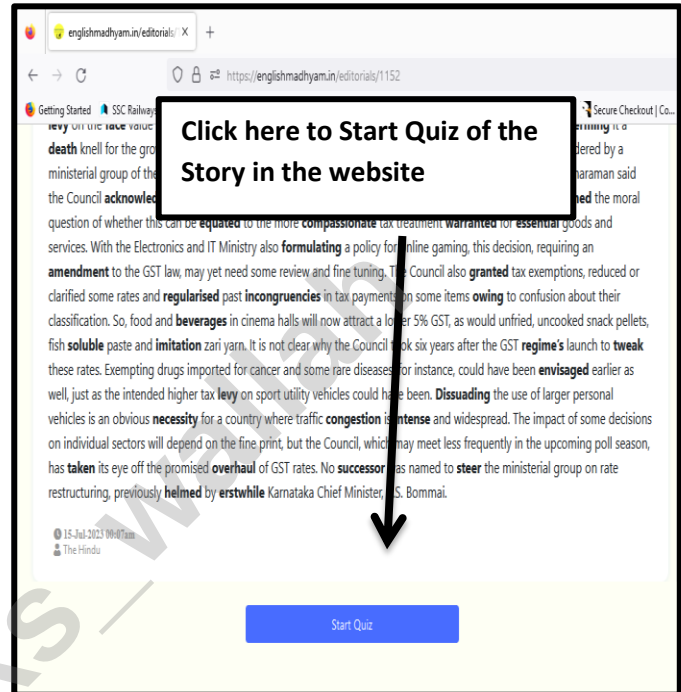
26. **Growling** (noun) – rumble, grumble, roar,
snarl, howl गुर्राना / गरजना

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